

Norman Foster

Accclaimed for his modernist designs and technological innovations, Sir Norman Foster (b.1935) leads one of the world's most famous architectural firms. Foster + Partners' vast number of projects around the world are characterized by their use of glass, stainless steel, exposed areas and unexpected forms. Key works include the iconic Hong Kong and Shanghai Bank Headquarters in Hong Kong (1979–86, opposite), built from five structural modules that were prefabricated in Scotland, and Berlin's Reichstag building (1992–9, resurrected from the old neoclassical German parliament). Other famous projects include the vast terminal building of Hong Kong International Airport (1991–98) and 30 St Mary Axe in London (2000–03, better known by its nickname of The Gherkin). Foster's buildings are often distinguished by the use of revolutionary and ecologically conscious elements. For example the HSBC building's vast ten-storey atrium is lit by a mirrored central sun-scoop, while the Reichstag's glass dome has an automated sunshade, as well as a spiral ramp that provides panoramic views of the city.

